

Parental linguistic scope matters in children's gender essentialism beyond children's explicit verbal agreement

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How parents talk (i.e., *linguistic scope*) about social categories predicts children's later beliefs.^[1]

For example:

Hearing generic statements about gender

"Girls put on makeup"
"Boys dig for worms"

Later essentialist thinking

to infer that group members share inherent traits that are universal and immutable ^[2,3]

Yet the exact mechanisms linking linguistic input to conceptual development **remain unclear**.

One Possible Pathway:
Children's immediate conversational uptake

Linguistic scope of parents' gendered language
(generic v. specific)

Child's immediate response
(agree, disagree, or neutral)

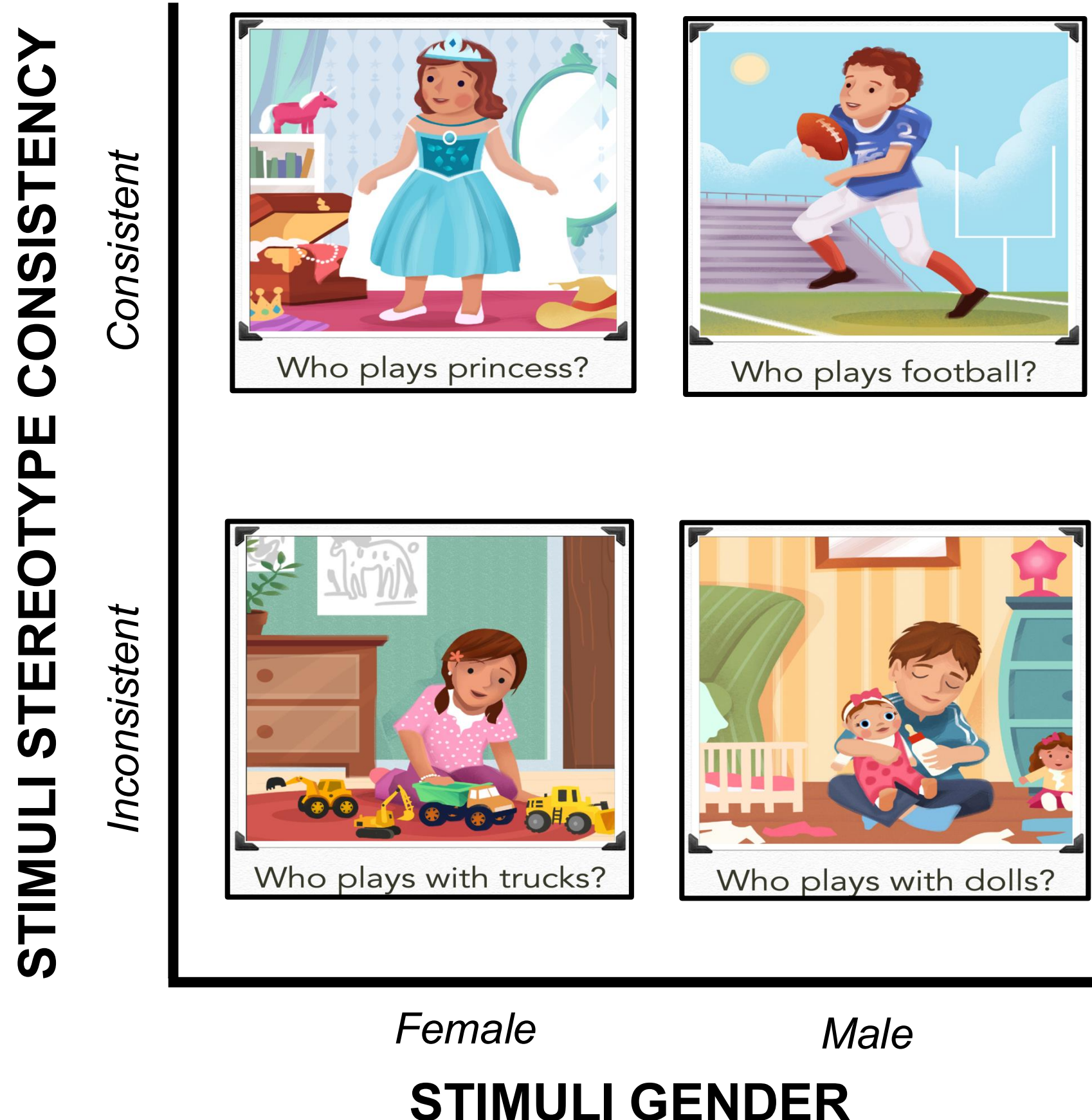
Child's later essentialist thinking

If children endorse/resist parental claims about gender, their immediate responses may signal **earlier internalization of category-level beliefs**.

Present Study:

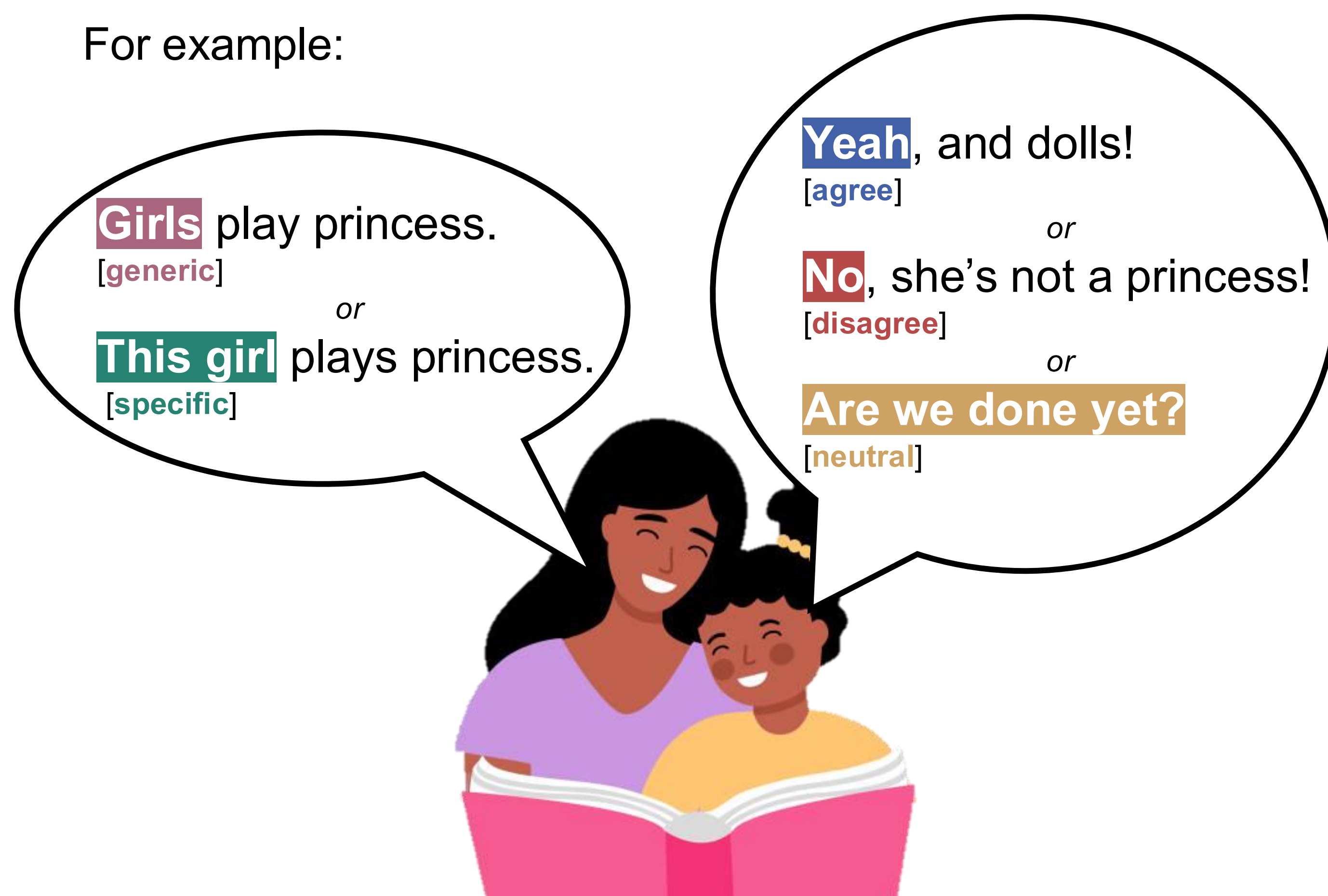
Examines whether children's immediate responses to parental gendered speech are associated with their later gender essentialist beliefs

From their home computers, parent-child dyads read through a picture book with prompts designed to elicit gendered talk:



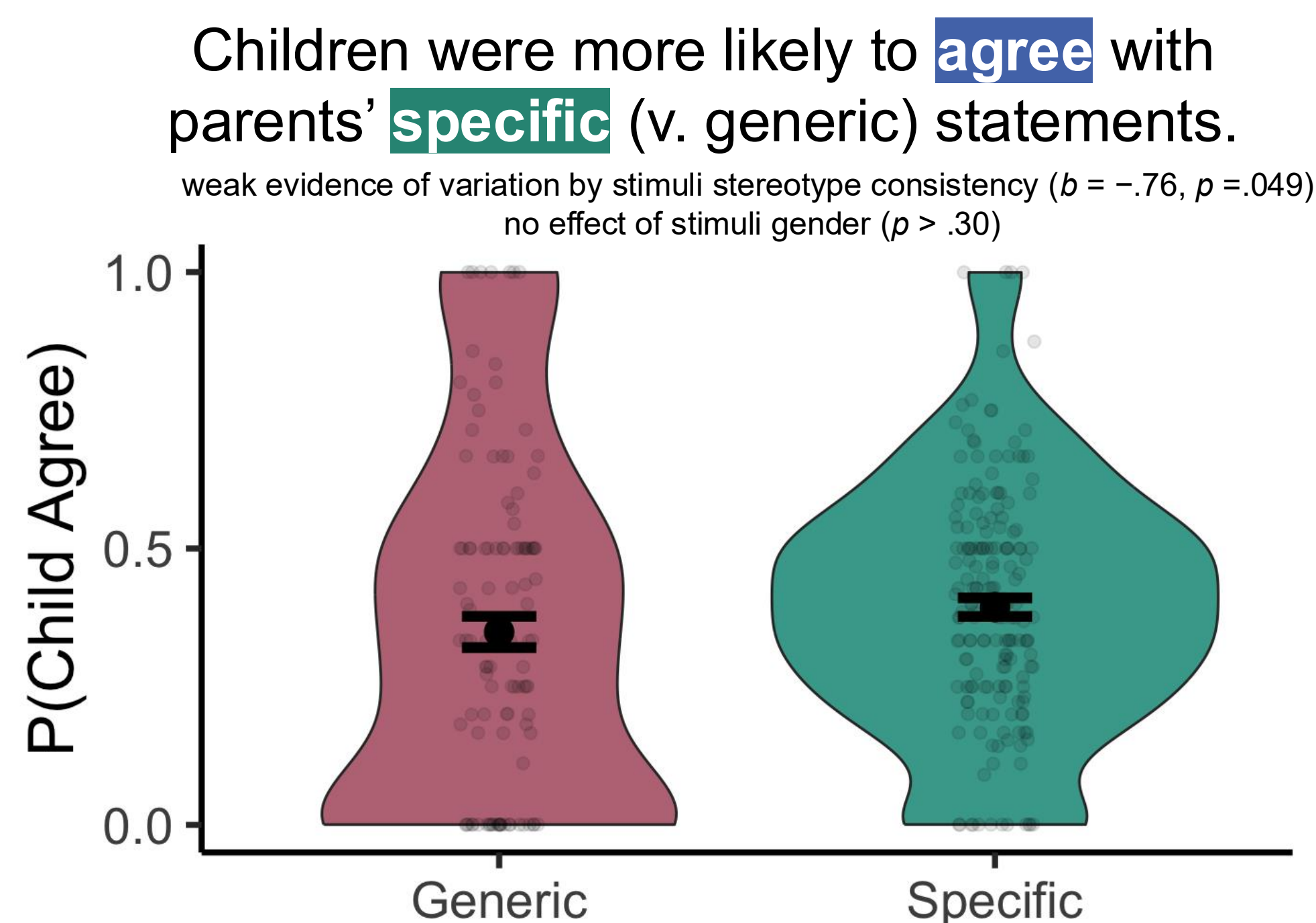
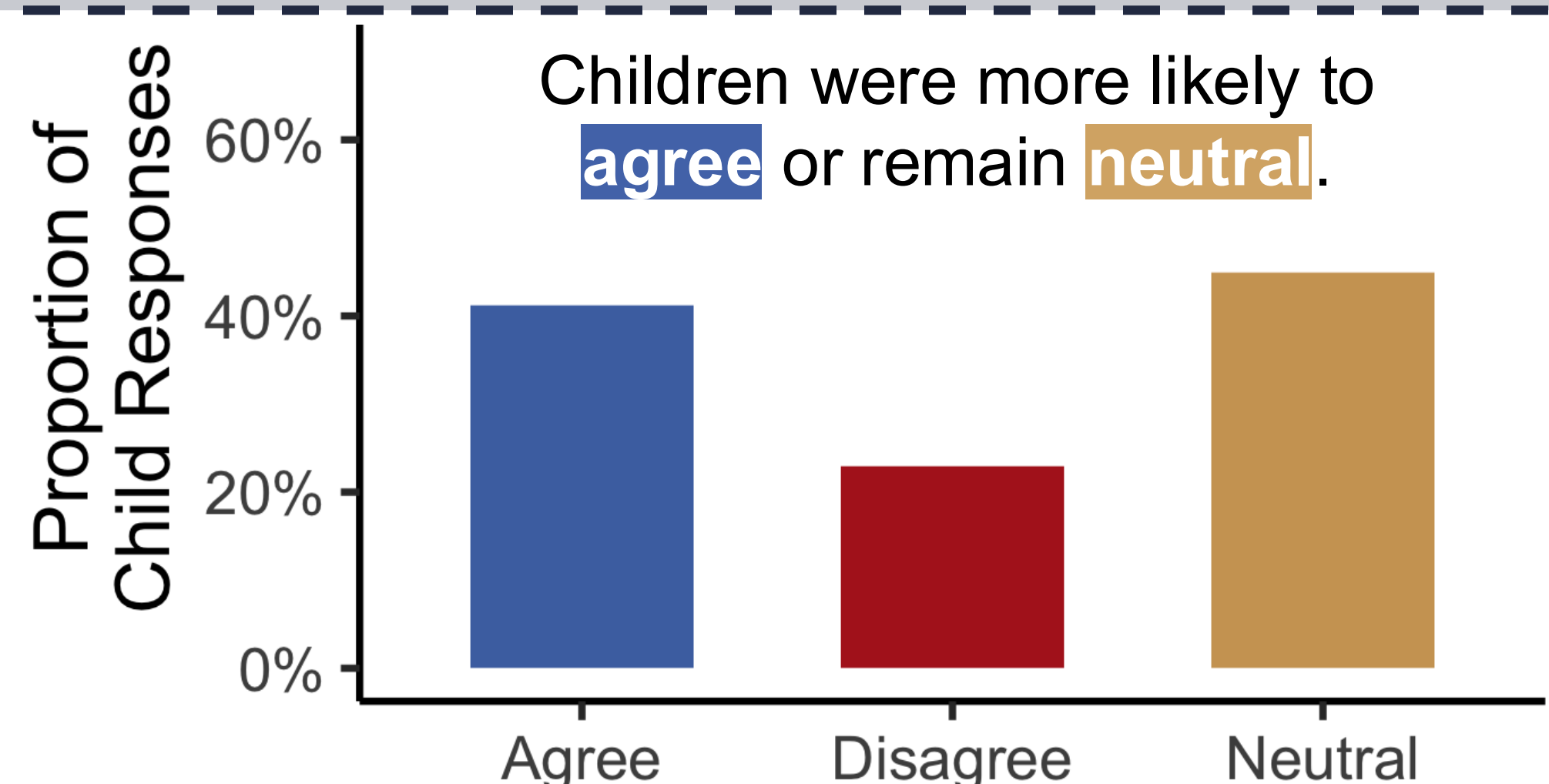
Using a dictionary-based approach, we coded children's immediate responses to parents' use of generic and specific statements about gender.

For example:



Session 1: Parent-Child Conversations

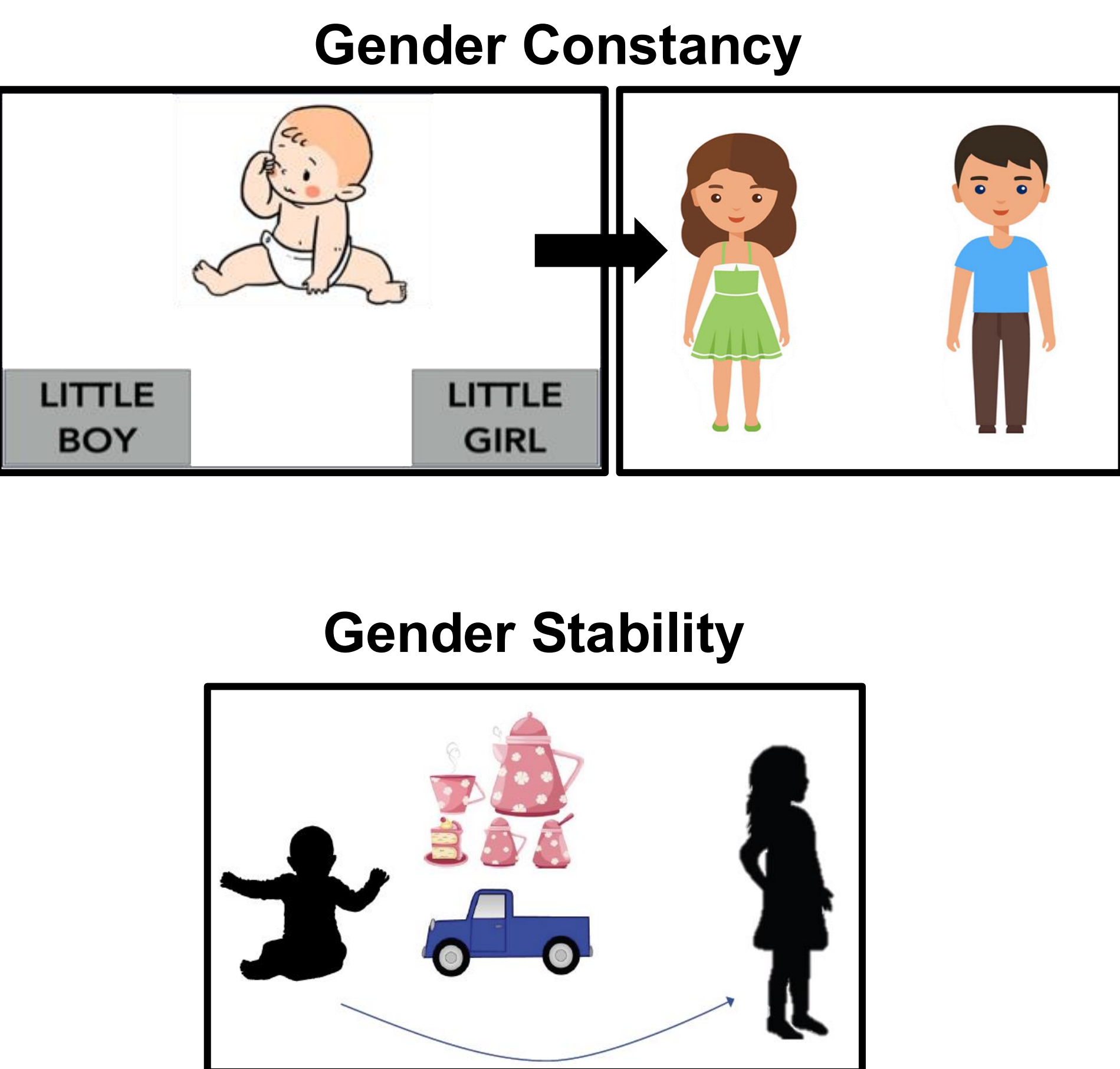
N = 191 dyads, 3-5 yo, M_{age}=4.5



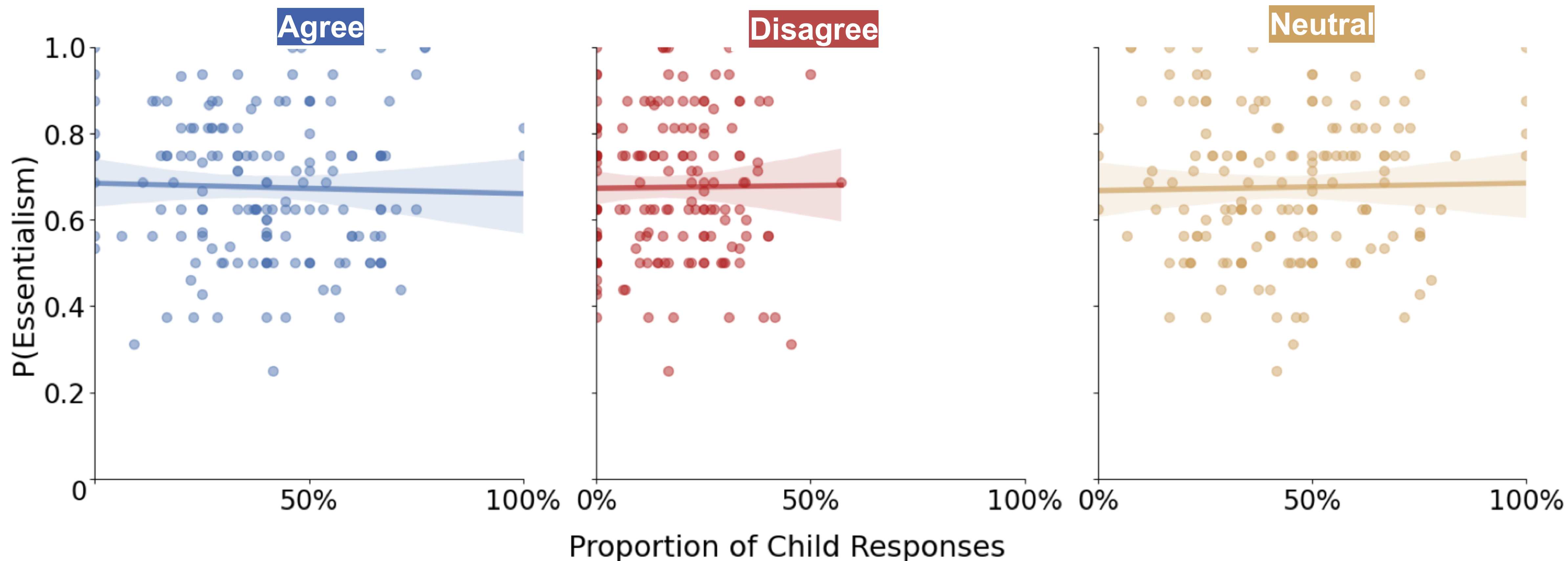
Session 2: Child Essentialist Beliefs

N = 117 children, 3-6 yo, M_{age}=4.7

At a later session, children were invited back to complete two gender essentialism measures to create an essentialism composite score:



Despite variability in how children responded to parents' statements about gender, children's immediate responses were **not** associated with their later gender essentialist beliefs.**
** linear regression models ($\beta \approx 0, p > .50$); correlational analyses (all r s $< .03, p$ s $> .70$)



Take-Away:

While children actively participate and differentially respond to gender talk in discourse, **verbal agreement $\neq$ internalization**.

Verbal agreement might signal *linguistic alignment* but not necessarily *conceptual alignment*.

Therefore, linguistic scope shapes beliefs through mechanisms beyond children's explicit responses.

↳ generics may activate *kind representation* over and above linguistic scope and content.

References

- [1] Benitez et al., (2022). *Cognition*.
- [2] Leshin et al. (2021). *Child Development*.
- [3] Benitez et al. (2025). *Journal of Experimental Psychology: General*.

